

[NT Lesson 42](#): “Pure Religion” James (See L42 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand the characteristics we should develop to live our religion more fully.

†1. President Spencer W. Kimball †2. “Pure Religion and Undefined”

1. We should endure affliction patiently.

• Read [James 1:1-4](#); [James 5:10-11](#). (See JST—James 1:2-3 *divers temptations* changed to *many afflictions*.)

What did James teach about facing trials of our faith?

How can trials help us develop patience? †3. Elder Orson F. Whitney †4. Carlfred Broderick

How are we blessed when we endure afflictions patiently? (See James 1:4; [Romans 5:3-5](#); [Alma 36:3](#).)

How have you seen latter-day prophets demonstrate this patience? How has their example helped you?

2. We should pray to God in faith.

• Read [James 1:5-7](#) and [James 4:8](#).

What experiences have you had with receiving answers to prayer?

How was the Prophet Joseph Smith influenced by the counsel in James 1:5?

What can we learn from his experience? †5. President Spencer W. Kimball †6. Elder Bruce R. McConkie

What can we do to strengthen our faith?

How does sincere prayer bring us closer to God?

3. We should control our tongues and be “slow to wrath.”

• Read [James 1:19-20, 26](#) and [James 3:2-18](#).

• James 1:19-20, 26. Let “every man be swift to hear, slow to speak, slow to wrath”.

What experiences have taught you to be “swift to hear” and “slow to speak”?

How can we become better listeners and more thoughtful speakers?

How can we apply James’s counsel to “bridle” our tongues? (See James 4:11.) †7. Bridling our Tongues

• James 3:3-5. “Behold, we put bits in the horses’ mouths, ... and we turn about their whole body.”

What can we learn from these comparisons?

How can learning to control our words help us control other aspects of our lives?

• James 3:9-13. “Therewith bless we God ... and therewith curse we men, which are made after the similitude of God.”

How well does this work for us as we seek to become like Christ?

• James 3:16-18. “For where envying and strife is ... every evil work. But the wisdom that is from above is first pure”.

How can controlling our tongues help lead to peace?

Why is controlling our tongues an important part of pure religion?

4. We should be “doers of the word,” showing our faith by our works.

• Read [James 1:22-25, 27](#); [James 2:14-26](#); and [James 4:17](#).

• James 1:22-25, 27. “But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves.

“Pure religion ... To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep ... unspotted from the world.”

What does it mean to be “hearers only” of the word?

In what sense do “hearers only” deceive themselves?

What are the blessings of being “doers of the word”?

Why do you think visiting and helping people in need is part of pure religion?

What can we do to stay “unspotted from the world?” (See [D&C 59:9](#).)

How does attending church and partaking of the sacrament each week help us stay unspotted from the world?

• James 2:14-26. “What doeth it profit ... though a man say he hath faith, and have not works? Can faith save him?”

Why is faith dead without works?

How do good works strengthen our faith in Jesus Christ?

Next Week: L43 “A Chosen Generation”; See L43: [Class Member Study Guide](#).

Read the Institute New Testament Student Manual at: [New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212](#).) † •

NT42 Quotes

†1. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “Unlike the Apostle Paul, James did not expound much in detail upon doctrines of the gospel. Rather, this epistle provides teachings of Christian wisdom and examples of how disciples of Jesus Christ should live their lives as expressions of their faith in Jesus Christ—we are to be ‘doers of the word, and not hearers only’ (James 1:22).” (*New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212*, [Chapter 50: James](#))

†2. **“Pure Religion and Undefined”:** “If the author of the epistle of James was the half brother of Jesus as the evidence seems to indicate, then perhaps he knew the Master as intimately as anyone. But later he knew the Savior as more than a brother. With a witness born of the Spirit, he knew him as Lord and God. James’ writing cannot help but reflect those lessons learned in childhood as he grew with Jesus, always being led and enlightened by his eldest brother’s example. It is of little wonder, then, that James focuses on the essence of pure religion as a very practical, down-to-earth activity. Religion, he teaches, is what we do because of testimony and love. So he focuses on the little things of which the stairway to perfection and exaltation are built. He understood well the principle taught by a modern apostle:

“‘There is no one great thing that we can do to obtain eternal life, and . . . the great lesson to be learned . . . is to apply in the little acts and duties of life the glorious principles of the Gospel. . . . Life after all, is made up of little things. . . . the true Christian life is made up of little Christ-like acts performed this hour, this minute, in the home, in the quorum, in the organization, in the town, wherever our life and acts may be cast.’” (David O. McKay in Conference Report, Oct. 1914, pp. 87–88. In *The Life and Teachings of Jesus and His Apostles*, Section 49, Introduction.)

†3. **Elder Orson F. Whitney:** “No pain that we suffer, no trial that we experience is wasted. It ministers to our education, to the development of such qualities as patience, faith, fortitude and humility. All that we suffer and all that we endure, especially when we endure it patiently, builds up our characters, purifies our hearts, expands our souls, and makes us more tender and charitable, more worthy to be called the children of God” (quoted in Spencer W. Kimball, *Faith Precedes the Miracle* [1972], 98).

†4. **Carlfred Broderick:** “The gospel of Jesus Christ is not insurance against pain. It is resource in event of pain, and when that pain comes (and it will come because we came here on earth to have pain among other things), when it comes, rejoice that you have resource to deal with your pain.” (*The Uses of Adversity*, 7)

†5. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “Because the fourteen-year-old boy went out in the woods to pray, having read in the scriptures, . . . because he did live the revelations from on high, we have The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. We have all of the blessings that can make us the happiest people in the whole world, because a boy of fourteen went out into the woods to pray” (in Conference Report, Melbourne Australia Area Conference 1976, 23).

†6. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie on James 1:5:** “This single verse of scripture has had a greater impact and a more far reaching effect upon mankind than any other single sentence ever recorded by any prophet in any age. It might well be said that the crowning act of the ministry of James was not his martyrdom for the testimony of Jesus, but his recitation, as guided by the Holy Ghost, of these simple words which led to the opening of the heavens in modern times.

“And it might well be added that every investigator of revealed truth stands, at some time in the course of his search, in the place where Joseph Smith stood. He must turn to the Almighty and gain wisdom from God by revelation if he is to gain a place on that strait and narrow path which leads to eternal life.” (*Doctrinal New Testament Commentary*, 3:246-247)

†7. **Bridling our Tongues:** “Answers could include by avoiding gossiping, lies, quarreling, swearing, and angry words. Instead, we should use our tongues to speak kind words, to speak truth, to pray, and to make peace.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Recommended Reading:

1. [NT42 Enrichment.pdf](#) contains more quotes and links to articles, blogs, and talks.
2. *New Testament Student Manual: Religion 211-212*, [Chapter 50: James](#).
3. Lynn G. Robbins, “[What Manner of Men and Women Ought Ye to Be?](#)” *Ensign*, May 2011.

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